

Lament, Grief, and Honest Prayer

You are in charge of how far you go. You may stop at any point, and you may leave anything untouched. Use a general word if a specific one is too much. Nothing here is graded.

If you have thoughts of not wanting to be alive, or cannot keep yourself safe, do not continue: contact local emergency services or a crisis line now, and do not remain alone.

1 • Check-in (gently)

1. Is there a loss in your life that has received little space, support, or acknowledgment? Name it in a word or a phrase, or in a general word if a specific one is too much.

2. Is there something about which you feel angry, disappointed, confused, or abandoned in relation to God? Write it down without softening it.

3. When you read Psalm 13's questions, which one is closest to your own: forgetting, hiding, sorrow, an enemy prevailing, or another phrase from the psalm?

4. What have you been told, or told yourself, about whether it is acceptable to pray like this?

3 • Silence

Ten minutes, five, or none. Anchor phrase: "How long, O Lord?" Or: "Consider and answer me." If the silence becomes more than sorrow, stop, open your eyes, and ground yourself (Lesson 5).

4 • Journal

1. What did you find yourself grieving, or angry about, during the silence? Write it in whatever detail feels safe.

2. Psalm 13 moves through address, complaint, petition, and trust. Which of those four have you been skipping in your own prayers? Which have you been stuck in?

3. What loss have you felt unable or unwilling to grieve openly, because you believed you should be past it, or because hope seemed to forbid sorrow? Tears are one expression of grief, not the measure of whether grief is real.

4. Write one sentence that begins "God, I do not understand why..." and finish it truthfully.

6 • Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. Adjust the words if you need to.

I have spoken as honestly as I can today.

My grief does not disqualify me from God's presence.

I do not have to be finished with sorrow in order to pray.

Where trust is difficult, I am willing to remain with one honest word, or to receive support until words return.

Writing your own lament

Brief lament: one honest complaint and one request to God.

General lament: use the four movements without writing names or personal details.

Full lament: use the four movements with as much detail as you freely choose. Psalm 13 is your template. It does not need to be long, and it does not need to be poetic.

You do not have to complete all four movements. A lament without a statement of trust is still a complete prayer.

Address

Speak to God directly, by whatever name is yours for him.

Complaint

Say what is wrong. Ask “how long?” if that is your question. Do not soften it.

Petition

Ask for what you want, not for what you think you should want. Naming a desire is not endorsing it.

Trust

If you can, write it. If not, leave it blank, write “not yet,” or the smallest truth you can hold. A blank fourth part is an honest lament.

Read it to God. Then keep it. An unfinished lament is still prayer. If you feel at risk of harming yourself or someone else, stop and seek immediate help.